

When I turned 21, I was shocked at how much competition there was in the beer industry. Obviously I knew that you had your major players such as Budweiser and Busch, but did not realize just how many brands there were.



When I moved to Texas this past summer, I was bummed to not be able to get my beloved Rainier, but excited to try some of their regional favorites, namely Lone Star Beer (“The National Beer of Texas”). Interestingly, I found those very brands that are sources of regional pride often turn out to be actually owned by major players. I was shocked to discover that both of these brands (Rainier and Lone Star) are owned by Pabst, who not only makes Pabst Blue Ribbon (PBR) but many others, including 16 regional brands just like Rainier and Lone Star.



Going further down the rabbit hole, I realized that this wasn't just my experience. Many of my friends from the bay area's local favorite Lagunitas IPA turned out to be owned by the Dutch company Heineken. And those who swear by Mexican beer? Modelo, Corona, Pacifico, and Victoria are all from Constellation Brands, with Dos Equis, Bohemia Lager, Tecate, and more all from Heineken. While all of these are still brewed in Mexico, it is interesting to see how global businesses own and market them as local favorites.

One particularly surprising brand is “Fosters,” which is marketed as an Australian beer (including a Kangaroo logo and a distinct “oil can” shape), and is owned by... Japanese giant Asahi and



Dutch/International giant Heineken and brewed in... Fort Worth, TX and Manchester, England. While iconic, this beer is ironically now hard to find in Australia due to being seen as inauthentic and a foreign-marketed product.

Closer to home, I learned that Olympia Beer—founded in 1896 about 15 minutes from my Grandma’s house where my dad grew up—was bought by MillerCoors and moved to California. The production shut down in 2021, leaving behind only a sad abandoned factory. Funny enough, my dad ended up working as a sales rep for Miller in Honolulu, and still only drinks Miller Lite to this day. His profession clearly influenced his preferences, and by extension, mine. While I don’t have the same 100% brand loyalty, I default to Miller Lite when choosing a light beer largely because the other factors (price, packaging, advertising) are often nearly identical across brands (reflected by how the same companies own many beers).



I think that this experience (and beer in general) demonstrates how consumer behavior is often influenced by multiple factors simultaneously. Socially, my drink choice often depends on who I’m with or the occasion, reflecting how peer influence and context matter. On a personal level, family plays a role in my preferences, especially with respect to my decision to choose Miller Lite. Culturally, beer is tied to regional pride, and the appeal of “local” beers often stems from clever marketing that taps into that sense of place, even when the ownership is far from local.

In the end, I’m generally happy with my choice of beer, even if I tend to look at advertising efforts somewhat skeptically. It is clear that marketing has a very powerful impact, especially when it taps into identity, pride, and nostalgia. Understanding how factors like social context, emotional connections, and strategic branding all interact has made me a more thoughtful consumer. What initially seems like a simple choice is actually the result of many influences, and shows how brands compete for loyalty in a very crowded space.